

NOTE: Before we go ahead, it is important you identify what type of Windows license you own: Original Equipment Manufacturer (OEM) or Retail? If you purchased your system/laptop with Windows preinstalled, then you have what is called an OEM license. However, if you purchased a copy of Windows from Microsoft's online store or a retailer, you have a retail license (costs a bit more than an OEM license). The major point of difference between these two license types is that an OEM license copy of Windows is valid only on the first system (i.e. motherboard) that it is installed. Retail licenses, on the other hand, allow you to reinstall Windows on a new computer without having to worry about activation.

As stated in Chapter 3, the free upgrade to Windows 10 is valid for both OEM and retail licenses. However, if you own an OEM copy of Windows 7/8/8.1, do not try to install Windows 10 on a NEW PC, especially if you are changing the motherboard. After the upgrade, Windows 10 will still have an OEM license which will not be valid for a new system.



It is also possible to buy an OEM copy of Windows for installing on a new PC

So how exactly should I backup my system?

Step 1: Backup your files on another drive

The first files that you prioritize for a backup are personal files like photos and work-related documents stored on your primary system drive, i.e. the drive on which your operating system is installed (generally C: drive). Since a clean reinstall of Windows wipes all files on your primary system drive, you should copy these files over to another drive on your PC (D:, E., etc.). Note that if something goes wrong during your installation process and you cannot boot into your OS, you will not be able to access the files on your backup drive until you successfully reinstall/restore your OS or else physically connect the hard drive to another PC.

The best way to avoid this hassle is to use an external hard drive for the backup. This way, should you botch the installation, you can at least be assured of having easy access to your backup files. Another excellent option for this type of backup is to use a cloud storage service like Dropbox,